

SEPOY MUTINY OR INDIAN REBELLION IN 1857

SEPOY MUTINY 1857

- Sepoy Revolt, 1857 started at Barrackpur under the leadership of Mangal Pandey on 29 March 1857 and soon spread to Meerut, Delhi, Bengal and other parts of India. After the outbreak of the mutiny in Meerut, the rebels quickly reached Delhi, whose 81-year-old Mughal ruler, Bahadur Shah Zafar, was declared the Emperor of Hindustan. The name of the revolt is contested, and it is variously described as the Sepoy Mutiny, the Indian Mutiny, the Great Rebellion, the Revolt of 1857, the Indian Insurrection, and the First War of Independence.
- It was sparked by a combination of factors including economic hardship, political grievances, administrative issues, pay anomalies and social and religious concerns, particularly regarding the newly introduced Enfield rifle cartridges greased with animal fat. The immediate trigger was the introduction of these cartridges, which offended both Hindu and Muslim sepoys as they contained animal fat (cow and pig) and required biting off the ends before use.
- It created serious tension throughout the then-East Bengal, now Bangladesh. The resistance in Chittagong and Dhaka and skirmishes at Sylhet, Jhassore,, Rangpur, Pabna and Dinajpur had left Bangladesh in a state of alert and excitement. On 18 November 1857 the Native Infantry of Chittagong rose in open rebellion and released all prisoners from the jail. They seized arms and ammunition, ransacked the treasury, set the Magazine House on fire and proceeded towards Tippera.

- The offensive of the sepoy of Chittagong had an important bearing upon the company's defensive posture in Dhaka. Being apprehensive of a further uprising of the sepoy, the authorities sent three companies of the 54th Regiment and one hundred seamen to Dhaka. Simultaneously a Naval Brigade was sent to Jhassore, Rangpur, Dinajpur and in some other districts of Bangladesh.
- Organised local volunteers consisting mostly of European residents took special measures for the protection of Dhaka. The situation became tense when the Naval Brigade arrived at Dhaka to disarm the sepoy stationed there.
- On 22 November the sepoy stationed at Lalbagh resisted the process of disarming. In the skirmish that followed several sepoy were killed and arrested while many of them fled towards Mymensingh. Most of the fugitives were, however, arrested and put up for summary trial by a hurriedly constituted Court Martial. Of the accused sepoy 11 were sentenced to death and the rest were sentenced to life imprisonment. The judgement was executed rather hurriedly.

- Tension and excitement persisted in different parts of Bangladesh, especially in the districts of Sylhet, Mymensingh, Dinajpur and Jessore. Several skirmishes occurred between the fugitive sepoys and European soldiers in Sylhet and some other places resulting in loss of lives on both sides. Summary trials by local Judges of the captured and disarmed sepoys took place in Sylhet and Jhassore. Hanging and deportation were common features of these summary trials.
- The role and reaction of various classes of people of Bangladesh during the sepoy revolt present a gloomy picture. The landed aristocracy were decidedly opposed to the sepoys and some of them rendered logistic support to the Company authorities by supplying carts, carriages and elephants; informing the movements of the fleeing sepoys and finally organizing local volunteer corps to resist the sepoys.
- The government acknowledged such services of the landed aristocracy with thanks and subsequently awarded them titles of Nawab, Khan Bahadur, Khan Shaheb, Rai Bahadur, Rai Shaheb etc and rewarded them with all sorts of worldly gains.
- Bahadur Shah II was arrested at Humayun's Tomb and tried for treason by a military commission assembled at Delhi and exiled to Rangoon where he died in 1862, bringing the Mughal dynasty to an end. In 1877 Queen Victoria took the title of Empress of India on the advice of Prime Minister Benjamin Disraeli.

AFTERMATH

- The rebellion saw the end of the East India Company's rule in India. In August, by the Government of India Act 1858, the company's ruling powers over India were transferred to the British Crown. A new British government department, the India Office, was created to handle the governance of India, and its head, the Secretary of State for India, was entrusted with formulating Indian policy. The Governor-General of India gained a new title, Viceroy of India, and implemented the policies devised by the India Office.
- Another significant result of the rebellion was the beginning of the policy of [consultation](#) with Indians. It was widely felt that a lack of communication with Indian opinion had helped to precipitate the crisis. Accordingly, the new council of 1861 was given an Indian-nominated element.
- The traditional structure of Indian society began to break down and was eventually superseded by a Westernized class system, from which emerged a strong middle class with a heightened sense of Indian [nationalism](#).

PARTITION OF BENGAL (1905)

- Partition of Bengal in 1905 is a significant event in the history of Bengal. Orchestrated by the then Viceroy Lord Curzon, Bengal Presidency was split into two new provinces: East Bengal, Assam and West Bengal, Bihar and Odisha.
- The British vice royalty attributed this division to administrative reasons citing the difficulty of administering vast area in an efficient manner. In East Bengal, Muslims were majority while West Bengal was Hindu-majority.
- Hindu opposition: Hindus strongly opposed the partition seeing it as an attempt to weaken nationalist movement and divide Bengalis along communal lines. They also described it as “divide and rule” tactics of British Raj.
- Muslims welcome: Muslims, particularly in the East Bengal, welcomed the partition, with the hope for development of the provinces, expansion of education, new opportunities for job and enhanced social status. Though for short period of time, partition of Bengal contributed a lot through increasing education, creating employment opportunities and ensuring socio-economic development of the muslim of east bengal

REACTIONS

- Swadeshi movement: Indian Congress waged the Swadeshi Movement that ignited nationalist sentiment mostly among the Hindus leading to protests and boycott of British goods and institutions. Some radical Hindu organizations like “Anushilon Samity” also joined the movement.
- Annulment: Despite initial plans , the partition was annulled in 1911 to the disappointment of the Muslim community in East Bengal. They saw it as significant setback as they would’ve largely benefitted from this partition.
- The partition Bengal led to the founding of Muslim League on 30th December 1906. Nawab Khwaja Salimullah was its founder. The annulment of partition embittered the relation between two communities.

EARLY RESISTANCE MOVEMENTS AGAINST THE BRITISH IN BENGAL

- Sannasi and Fakir uprising (1770-1820): Fuelled by increased land revenue and exploitation of peasants by the British. Leaders like Fakir Majnu Shah (sufi saint), Bhabani Pathak (Hindu sannyasi), Debi Chowdhurani were involved in this resistance.
- Faraizi movement (1804-1860): Led by Haji Shariatullah and later Dudu Mian, this was one of the first no-tax campaigns against the British, involving significant local resistance against planters and zamindars.
- Secret movement by Anushilon Samity: Chittagong Armoury raid in 1930 led by Surya Sen.
- The Titumir Rebellion, also known as the Barasat Rebellion, was a peasant uprising in Bengal led by Syed Mir Nisar Ali, more popularly known as Titumir, against British colonial rule and local zamindars (landlords) in 1831.